SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #4 · FAMILY TRADITIONS AND HERITAGE

“Our family has always been this way, and it can't change.”

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Where it often comes from

Patterns such as anger, addiction, divorce, poverty, silence, or distance can run for generations, and people often say, “That is just how we are.” Hearing it repeated can make change feel disloyal or impossible.

What Scripture teaches

God told Israel through Ezekiel that the proverb about sins passing to the next generation would no longer be used, and said, “A son will not bear the iniquity of his father.” Paul writes, “If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” God promises, “I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you.” Patterns do shape us, but they are not destiny. One person who changes can begin a new pattern for those who follow.

> *“Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!”* (2 Corinthians 5:17).

Also see

> “Yet you may ask, ‘Why shouldn’t the son bear the iniquity of his father?’ Since the son has done what is just and right, carefully observing all My statutes, he will surely live. The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him” (Ezekiel 18:19–20).

> “I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will remove your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh” (Ezekiel 36:26).

> “‘Do not call to mind the former things; pay no attention to the things of old. Behold, I am about to do something new; even now it is coming. Do you not see it? Indeed, I will make a way in the wilderness and streams in the desert.’” (Isaiah 43:18–19).

> “Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind. Then you will be able to test and approve what is the good, pleasing, and perfect will of God” (Romans 12:2).

Common self-statements

- This is how we are.
- It runs in the family.
- We have never done it differently.
- Trying to change is pointless.
- I will end up like them.
- Change would betray the family.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting that nothing can change.
- Labeling: Treating “our family” as a fixed identity.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either conform or leave.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling stuck and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- Which patterns in my family do I want to keep, and which do I want to change?
- Has anyone in my family broken a pattern, even partly?
- What would a first small change look like?
- What does it mean to be a new creation?
- Who could support me in changing?
- What would I want my children or the next generation to say about me?

Truth summary

> Family patterns are real, but they are not destiny. In Christ I am a new creation, and God gives me a new heart. I can keep what is good, change what is harmful, and begin a better pattern.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Born Again
- Sinful Nature
- Parenting
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Holy Spirit

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Chain Breaker — Zach Williams
Christ offers rescue and freedom to people who feel trapped by their past.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Our family has always been this way, and it can't change"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Our family has always been this way, and it can't change." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What patterns do I see?
- ☐ What do I want to keep?
- ☐ Who broke a pattern?
- ☐ What first step?
- ☐ Who supports me?
- ☐ What do I hope for the next generation?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ God gives me a new heart.
- ☐ Patterns are not destiny.
- ☐ I can keep the good and change the harmful.
- ☐ Each person answers for their own choices.
- ☐ A new pattern can begin with me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"
- ☐ Ezekiel 36:26
  "I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit within you; I will remove your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh."
- ☐ Ezekiel 18:19–20
  "Yet you may ask, 'Why shouldn't the son bear the iniquity of his father?' Since the son has done what is just and right, carefully observing all My statutes, he will surely live. The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ A new pattern: Each week, note one thing you did differently from the old pattern.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 2 Corinthians 5:17 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am a new creation in Christ, not a copy of the past.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Born Again" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ List the patterns. Write what to keep and what to change.
- ☐ Pick one change. Choose a small, specific change.
- ☐ Get support. Tell a pastor or friend what you are trying.
- ☐ Repair quickly. When you slip, apologize and begin again.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Our family has always been this way, and it can't change": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A new pattern
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Our family has always been this way, and it can't change.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, change begins with You. Give me a new heart, show me what to keep and what to leave, and make me the beginning of something healthier for my family. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.